

fixtures, a welcome change from years of calendars filled with blots of emptiness. The focus now is on the quality of opponent one can afford to face. Within the Asian fold itself, a tiered system operates where the likes of India, in particular, barely face Associates. So regardless of how futile a pampered cricket fan might think these tournaments are, they are, so far at least, the only avenues for teams to experience a top-class global opponent.

The knowledge transfer, by itself, becomes the biggest takeaway for so many of these teams. Images of Hong Kong players flocking around India's senior players and Japan and China players lining up for photographs with women they had only watched in videos or heard about in lore passing over from the subcontinent made for heartening visuals. Hong Kong China's Marina Lamplough's videos through the Asia Cup, in which she showed glimpses of how the team took notes from the Indian openers' style and strategy, are one such example.

But that's as deep as the engagement goes. India's 'responsibility' to democratise its presence in the Asian circuit now has the hurdle of a packed calendar standing before it.

In the Asian Games and Asia Cup, the eastern cricketing wave doesn't realise what it has, Netherlands skipper Babette de Leede pointed out, highlighting Asia's advantage over other continental groupings.

"You know how Asia has the Asian Games and the Asia Cup? We don't have any of that in Europe. It would be great because you get more games. Look at the difference between the number of games we play and the number Australia or India play. We do have entities like the European Cricket Network... the T10 tournament they organise. Those numbers are developing. And now there's the European T20 Premier League too. If there was something like that for us in Europe, it would be quite cool," she told *Sportstar* on the sidelines of the T20 World Cup earlier this year.

The wish for integration isn't random. With cricket making the Los Angeles Summer Games, the ecosystem hopes this is the start of a long stay in the Olympic roster. In 2028, six teams each will compete in the men's and women's events, with rankings deciding the majority of the slots and qualifiers filling the gaps. The Asian Games is no different: an eight-team tournament that begins at the quarterfinal stage in a continental showpiece involving 46 countries.

In Aichi-Nagoya, China didn't even get to play, despite making the cut, after rain washed out its quarterfinal against Bangladesh, the latter advancing due to higher seeding. Cricket's intense weather vulnerabilities leave teams on the bigger stage of amateur sport short-changed when months of preparation and dreams can drown in a downpour.

Work at the roots

The International Cricket Council, especially after the recent FIFA World

Pics: R. V. MOORTHY

